

people. He resumed composition of the Ring cycle, abandoned since the 1850s, finishing the third opera, Siegfried, in 1871 and the final work in the sequence, Götterdämmerung, in 1874. With Ludwig II's backing, he built a theater at Bayreuth in northern Bavaria to stage his masterpiece. The first complete performance of the Ring cycle in 1876 was a major cultural event with a celebrity audience. The cycle has maintained its fascination ever since, its symbolism attracting diverse interpretations ranging from Marxist anti-capitalism to Freudian psychodrama.

Later years

Wagner lived for the rest of his life at Wahnfried, the villa he had built by the Bayreuth theater. His final creative project was Parsifal, an operatic version of the legend of the Holy Grail, completed in 1882. He regarded it as a sacred work, to be performed exclusively at Bayreuth so it would not degenerate into an "entertainment." His apparent embrace of a mystical Christianity alienated some of his previous admirers, including the philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche. Other critics have viewed the opera as an expression of Wagner's racial theories and anti-Semitism.

Wagner's habits of a lifetime never changed. He still ran into debt and he was unfaithful to his wife. It was after a marital fight that he died of a heart attack in Venice in 1883. His body was brought back to Bayreuth for burial. Cosima Wagner became the self-appointed guardian of the purity of performances of Wagner's operas at the annual Bayreuth Festival, a role she maintained into the 20th century.